

Headphones: The right one for you

Shakespeare wrote, "If music be the food for love, play on." Well, if you really want to enjoy music, you ought to have the right pair of headphones

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Whether it is about commuting from home to office or spending some private moments, a good set of headphones has become a part of our lives. With various options available in the market, it is confusing to choose the right headphone.

There are a host of headphones available from some of the finest brands. While a few of them are good to be used at home because of their size, most of them, which are more portable, add to the music experience while on the go. The four main types presently available in the market are:

1. Over-ear headphones. These large headphones cover the ears, almost completely. The cushioned pads on them make them comfortable enough to be worn for a longer period of time. These headphones offer good sound quality and are great for using at home.

2. On-ear headphones. These are sleeker, smaller and lighter than over-ear headphones. Designed to sit on the ear, these are padded with foam or leatherette. Many on-ear headphones come in a foldable design, making them easy to carry around. However, some have an open-back design and the base levels of these cannot match the levels set by

the closed-back ones, including over-ear headphones. So, you might have to compromise with the sound quality.

3. In-ear headphones. Also known as earphones, these can be inserted into the ear canal. The ear canal is almost sealed with the earphone's rubber head, isolating the noise around. These are best suited for places where noise blockage is required.

4. Earbuds. An earbud sits at the entry of the ear canal, but does not actually go inside. It has a flat or a slightly curvy surface. Because these do not offer an air-tight seal, noise blockage doesn't happen when you use them. The audio experience of earbuds is disappointing.

Factors one should look for before buying a headphone:

Value for money. Headphones are available in all price ranges. Expensive headphones are made up of better engineering and high-quality material and provide improved sound quality. Before making a purchase, check for the basic sound quality and durability levels of the headphones.

Sound isolation factor. Whether you buy headphones for enhancing your music experience or enjoying gaming, sound isolation factor is of utmost importance. It means how well a pair of headphones blocks outside noise. In-

ear headphones, earbuds and DJ-style headphones serve you well in this area, as they seal the ear almost completely.

Noise cancellation feature. Noise cancellation feature reduces unwanted ambient sound but it comes at a cost. This feature makes it possible to enjoy music without raising the volume excessively. In the aviation environment, noise-cancelling headphones increase the signal-to-noise ratio significantly more than passive noise attenuating headphones or no headphones, making hearing important information such as safety announcements easier. These headphones can improve listening, enough to completely offset the effect of a distracting concurrent activity.

However, most experts suggest that this feature is not worth the investment. And if you really need to, you might consider earbuds with sponges that can fill the ear canal. Also, over-ear hearing protectors can be worn over earbuds to cancel ambient noise.

Frequency range. The frequency range of headphones determines how much you can hear of your music. It is good to choose headphones with a wider frequency range. Frequency ranges between 10 Hz to 25,000 Hz are considered to be good as it covers the entire audible frequency range for human beings.

HEADPHONES AVAILABLE IN INDIA

	Sony MDR-10RBT Bluetooth Headphones	Sony Headphone MDR-ZX310	Panasonic RP-TCM190 In-Ear Earphone	Skullcandy Ink'd 2.0 Headphone With Mic	Philips Headphone SHS990-98	iBall iRocker Back Earphone
						
Price	₹ 14,990	₹ 1290	₹ 1299	₹ 1499	₹ 499	₹ 599
USP	Its liquid crystal polymer film diaphragm adds to the quality of the sound.	Cheap, lightweight, decent looks.	Its bass is appreciated. It has a cord slider for tangle-free storage.	Its supreme sound delivers attacking bass, natural vocals and precision highs. It has a flattened cable for style and durability.	It is a decent combination of comfort, style and sound quality. At its price.	This is a stylish and flexible back earphone with powerful bass and super sound quality.

The prices mentioned here are from various e-commerce portals and are subject to change.